

PART 1B: OTHER FACTIONS

by Justin Alexander – November 29th, 2018



Moving beyond the major villains, the Grand Game also features the participation of any number of other factions (including the PCs).

GRALHUNDS

The Gralhunds are a minor faction (at least compared to the four main villains) involved in the Grand Game. They simply hope to obtain the Vault for themselves, and use its riches to elevate their position in Waterdeep's high society. (As described on p. 213, the Gralhunds believe that Lady Yalah should have been elevated to the Masked Lords years ago following the events in the novel [Death Masks](#).)

Many dismiss the Gralhunds as petty schemers, but the truth is that they have had to be clever and conniving in order to punch above their weight-class in Waterdeep's labyrinthine politics. Even now, as they play the Grand Game, they are struggling to compete with organizations that are far larger and have far more resources.

Thinking outside of the box, they embedded agents in Renaer Neverember's household months ago. Because Renaer was estranged from his father, they knew it was a long-shot, but it paid off: The agents spotted Dalakhar's surveillance of Renaer and identified him as an agent of Lord Neverember. When Dalakhar was abruptly pulled off of that assignment, the agents followed a hunch, followed up, and discovered he had ended up in Xanathar's organization (presumably still on orders from Lord Neverember). The Gralhunds didn't know that Xanathar held the *Stone of Golorr*, but when it was stolen they were among the first to suspect (and then know) that Dalakhar was responsible.



THE NIMBLEWRIGHT: Two days after Dalakhar stole the *Stone*, the Gralhunds located him and dispatched their newly acquired nimblewright to find him. In Trollskull Alley, the nimblewright uses a *fireball* spell to kill Dalakhar and the Zhentarim agents trailing him. The nimblewright then grabs the *Stone of Golorr* from Dalakhar's corpse and flees the scene, returning to the Gralhund Villa with his prize (see Part 2).

DESIGN NOTE

The key decision here was to simplify the Gralhund back story. This quickly eliminates a whole slew of continuity errors from the campaign and simplifies a rather convoluted intrigue that the players are unlikely to ever fully fathom. But we've also simultaneously increased the scope of the Grand Game (by establishing that there are numerous minor factions all wrapped up in the intrigue) and given ourselves the opportunity to dynamically increase the number of factions involved in the Gralhund Villa sequence (see Part 2).

OTHER MINOR FACTIONS

OPEN LORD: The Open Lord of Waterdeep isn't exactly a "minor" faction, but Laeral Silverhand is considerably behind the curve in the current Grand Game. She knows that Lord Neverember embezzled 500,000 dragons from the city, but as *Dragon Heist* begins she is under the belief that he already has the money in Neverwinter. She has agents working to recover it there, but little hope of succeeding (as she believes it has likely already been laundered into Neverember's expansive plans for rebuilding and expanding Neverwinter). She has heard rumors of Neverember's Enigma, but has yet to connect that with the missing dragons, and is also unaware of the *Stone of Golorr* (although she knows that a powerful artifact was stolen from the palace during the confused time period when Neverember was being ousted from power).

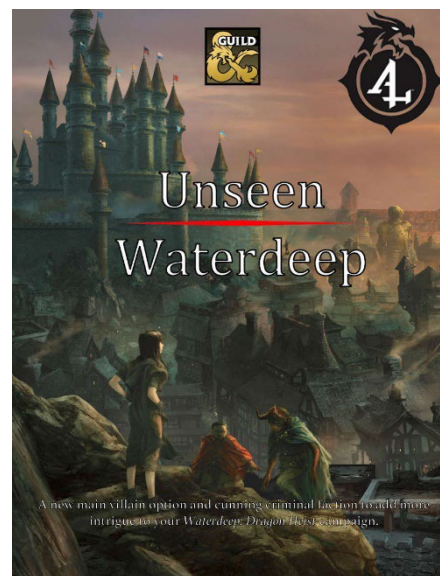
The most likely avenue for that to change — and potentially change rapidly — is through information blabbed to the City Watch. This could happen as early as Scenario 1 (depending on exactly what Renaer and/or the PCs report to the watch), but it's quite possible for the Open Lord to *never* fully twig to what's happening.

THE UNSEEN: James Introcaso, one of the original designers for *Dragon Heist*, wrote a supplement for the campaign called [Unseen Waterdeep](#). It includes a new villain for the campaign — a half-doppelganger, half-illithid hybrid running a small gang of shapechangers who wants the gold in order to fund bribes to

discover the identities of the Masked Lords (who he intends to assassinate and replace with his shapechangers).

If you want to crank up the byzantine complexities of the Grand Game by adding in more villainous factions, the Unseen are a great plug-and-play option for that. I'm not going to discuss them at great length, but:

- Consider introducing the Unseen by having them send a doppelganger disguised as a friend or ally of the PCs to politely pump them for information. (They may also be targeting other factions with the same tactic. Their goal is to quickly play catch-up in the Grand Game.)
- I would avoid adding the Unseen to the Gralhund Villa sequence (see Part 2). Partly to keep that complexity of the sequence under control, but mostly because adding them a little later will create the feeling that the Grand Game is attracting more attention and the stakes are ratcheting up.
- However, if the PCs have staged a successful heist on Jarlaxle's ship without tipping him off about Neverember's Enigma, then the Unseen can very easily slip in and fill that vacuum in any sequence where I discuss Bregan D'Aerthe's involvement.



DESIGN NOTES

The Unseen also make a convenient exemplar for how other factions of your own design can be added to the campaign. Note that their method of introduction to the campaign is via a unique vector: The Zhentarim have kidnapped people. Cassalanter asks the PCs for help (perhaps in exchange for a percentage). The PCs have to ask Jarlaxle for help. The Gralhunds launched a violent assault. The Unseen's introduction comes via social subterfuge and deceit. Similarly, the Unseen are also capable of deploying tactics that the other factions can't. If you're adding a new faction, try to make sure they're bringing something new to the table, and not just rehashing what the current factions already provide.

BONNIE'S DOPPELGANGERS / THE BLACK VIPER: These aren't really factions. They're small, independent operators who almost certainly lack the resources to go up against the big players. (Of course, the same thing could be said of the PCs.)

Whatever the case may be, Bonnie's Doppelgangers and the Black Viper are good examples of small-time players who can get swept up in the Grand Game.

- They might interfere with heists. (Either pursuing the same objective or just coincidentally breaking into the same establishment in pursuit of some other item of value.)
- They might be hired by NPCs to accomplish any number of ends. But, in particular, they might seek to steal the *Stone* and/or the *Eyes* from the PCs.
- They might also offer their services to the PCs (or be found by the PCs if they go looking for such services).

(Bonnie's doppelgangers are described on p. 20 and are part of faction missions on p. 35 and 37. The Black Viper is described on p. 196 and is part of faction missions on p. 39 and 40. She also appears at the Cassalanter Estate, as described on p. 118.)